

WRAPCOLS Function in Excel

1. What is WRAPCOLS?

The WRAPCOLS function takes a single row or column of values and wraps it into a table, filling one column at a time. You decide how many values go in each column. It solves the problem of long lists that are hard to read or print. A Data Analyst uses it to reshape lists into compact tables and to split a list into equal groups.

2. Syntax

`=WRAPCOLS(vector, wrap_count, [pad_with])`

Argument	Required?	What it accepts
vector	Required	A single row or a single column of values (for example A1:A6). A table with several columns and rows does not work.
wrap_count	Required	The maximum number of values in each column, which is the height of the result. A value of 3 means 3 rows.
pad_with	Optional	The value to put in any empty cells, such as "" or "-". The default is #N/A.

Excel fills the first column from top to bottom, then starts a new column to the right. It works out the number of columns itself: 6 values with a wrap_count of 3 make 2 columns, and 7 values make 3 columns with 2 empty cells.

3. Simple Example

Wrap a list of 6 items into a table with 3 rows:

	A	B	C	D
1	Apple		Apple	Mango
2	Banana		Banana	Kiwi
3	Orange		Orange	Grape
4	Mango			
5	Kiwi			
6	Grape			

Formula in C1 only: `=WRAPCOLS(A1:A6, 3)`
Each column holds 3 values. Excel fills the first column with Apple, Banana, Orange, then starts a second column with Mango, Kiwi, Grape. **Result: 3 rows and 2 columns**

4. Another Example

Arrange 5 employees into teams of up to 3, one team per column:

	A	B	C	D
1	Name		Team 1	Team 2
2	Ayesha		Ayesha	Fahim
3	Rahim		Rahim	Sadia
4	Nabila		Nabila	-
5	Fahim			
6	Sadia			

Formula in C2 only: `=WRAPCOLS(A2:A6, 3, "-")` (the headings in C1:D1 are typed)
Five names make two columns. Team 1 gets 3 names. Team 2 gets only 2, so the empty cell is filled with the pad value "-" instead of #N/A.

5. When to Use It

- Turn a long list into a compact table for reading or printing
- Split a list into equal groups, such as teams, with one group per column
- Prepare a compact layout of items for a dashboard
- Reshape a single-column result, such as from UNIQUE, into a table
- Rebuild a table from a flattened list, for example after using TOCOL

6. Important Things to Remember

- WRAPCOLS fills column by column: top to bottom, then left to right. Its partner WRAPROWS fills row by row.
- wrap_count is the number of values in each column (the table height), not the number of columns.
- vector must be a single row or column, or Excel shows #VALUE!. A wrap_count below 1 gives #NUM!.
- Empty cells show #N/A unless you give a pad_with value.
- WRAPCOLS is a dynamic array function. The cells for the result must be empty, or Excel shows #SPILL!.
- WRAPCOLS is available in Microsoft 365 and Excel 2024, but not in Excel 2021 or earlier.

7. Common Mistakes

Mistake: Thinking wrap_count is the number of columns. `=WRAPCOLS(A1:A6, 3)` gives 3 rows and 2 columns, not 3 columns. **Fix:** To get 3 columns from 6 values, use a wrap_count of 2.

Mistake: Selecting a range with several columns, which gives #VALUE!. **Fix:** Use a single row or column. Flatten a table first with TOCOL or TOROW.

Mistake: Leaving #N/A in the result because pad_with was left out. **Fix:** Add a pad value, such as "".

Mistake: Getting #SPILL! because cells where the result will go already contain data. **Fix:** Clear those cells or move the formula to an empty area.

8. Data Analyst Tip

To get a set number of columns, calculate the wrap_count. For example, `=WRAPCOLS(A2:A20, ROUNDUP(COUNTA(A2:A20)/3, 0), "")` wraps the list into 3 columns, however many items there are.